

India's strengths and foibles. The South African, a former India coach, has his admirers in the Indian cricketing establishment but they are wary about his acquired knowledge over the years.

Sri Lanka bats deep and skipper Dhananjaya de Silva would hope that his willow-wielders can stand firm against the visitors. Men like Dinesh Chandimal have to replicate the past exploits of Arjuna Ranatunga, Roy Dias, Aravinda de Silva, Roshan Mahanama, Sanath Jayasuriya, Mahela Jayawardene and Kumar Sangakkara.

With just the narrow Palk Strait splitting India and Sri Lanka, the neighbouring country presents this same-same-but-different vibe. Gill's men have to cope with this paradox in a tropical paradise that, in the past, offered a break to cricketers taking the ship between England and Australia.

Gill also gets a chance to infuse his spirit into the team after the looming shadows cast by Kohli and Rohit have vanished. Countering the guiles of left-arm spinner Prabath Jayasuriya would be a key battle, be it at the sea-kissed Galle or in the bustling urban sprawl that Colombo represents.

Elsewhere, reputations are often burnished in the heat and dust of Tests, and for pacers like Auzib Nabi and Gurnoor Brar, the tour presents an opportunity to reiterate their skills. The same is true for spinner

Manav Suthar and all-rounder Saransh Jain. A key element that can influence India's fortunes will be the form of Rishabh Pant. The maverick keeper-batter needs to rediscover his mojo.

A tough season awaits India as Australia will soon be among the visiting teams. A winning yield in Sri Lanka will bolster the squad and help Gill carry his unit towards more laurels. Conflating results between the blue and white shades has often left a mixed bag, and India, the strong Test squad, has to resurface again.

It would be prudent to remember that Sri Lanka has often ambushed India in the past, and across formats.

Gambhir and Gill will still lean on their recency bias and believe that this is a series India should rightfully claim. Sri Lanka, meanwhile, will search for mystery spinners and deft batters to derail its opponent.

A crucial August will highlight whether India's Test cogs are in sync, even as Sri Lanka invests in spinners humming a lullaby before going for the jugular. In a land where writers like Shehan Karunatilaka and Ashok Ferrey chart magical stories, Gill's men want to add their surreal touch.

Past perfect: India's batting core has moved on from Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma. K. MURALI KUMAR



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